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General Knowledge
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Freedom Movement
(1939-1947)

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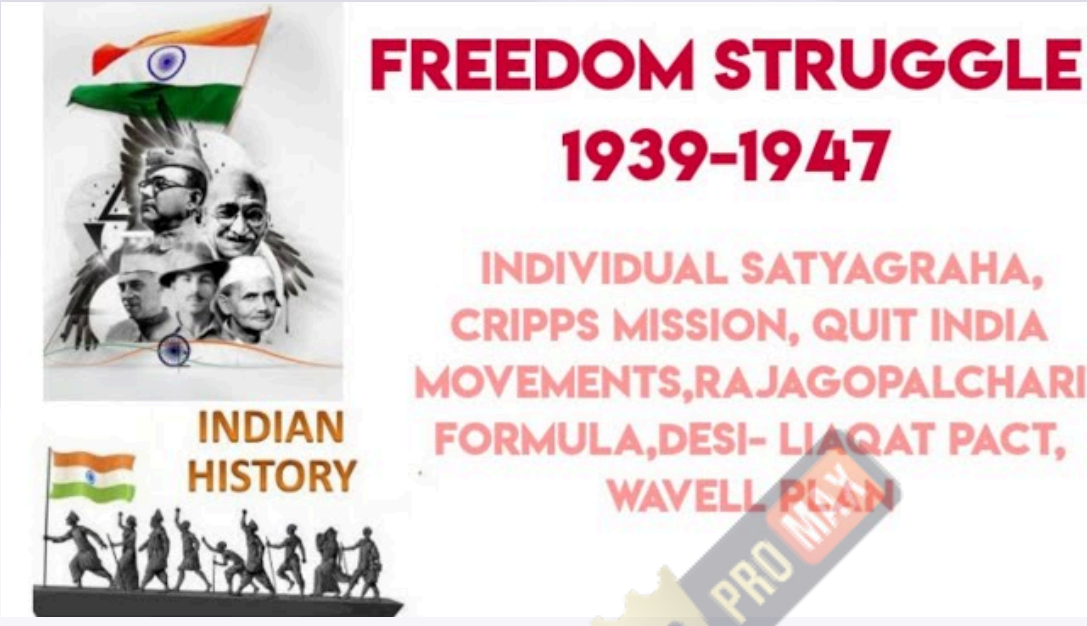
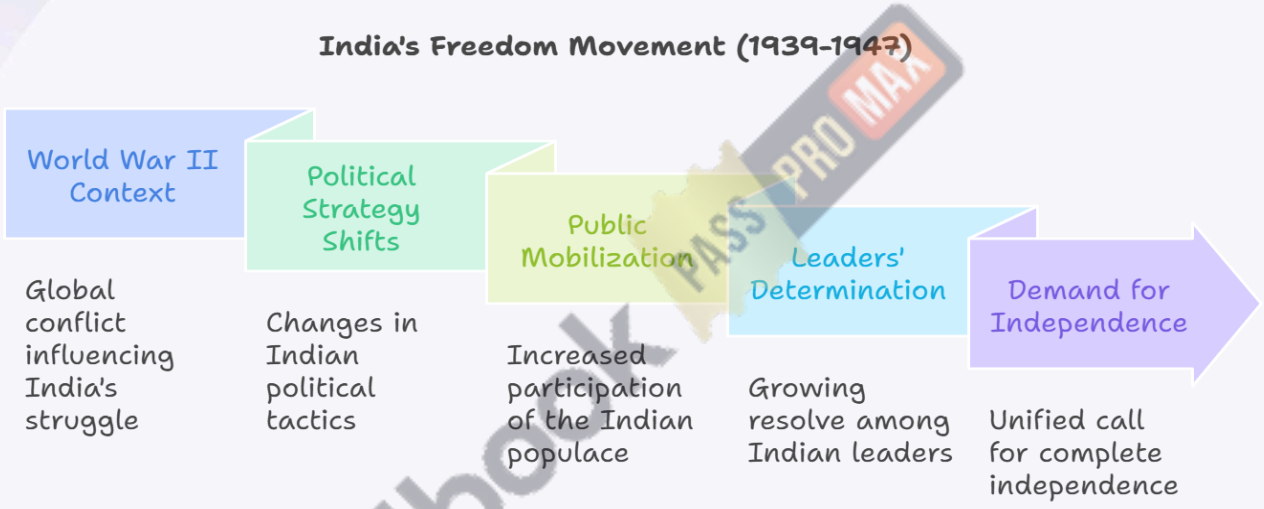


Introduction

- The **period between 1939 and 1947** marked a decisive phase in India's journey to independence, influenced by both global and domestic factors.
- As World War II unfolded, the British Empire faced a significant threat, struggling to maintain its grip on colonies amidst **rising international opposition** to imperialism.
- India, central to Britain's wartime strategy for its resources and manpower, became a crucial player in the war effort.
- However, Britain's unilateral decision to involve India in the war without consulting Indian leaders was seen as a gross disregard for Indian sovereignty and was the tipping point for the intensification of the freedom struggle.
- By 1939, the Indian National Congress (INC) had solidified itself as the primary representative of Indian aspirations, advocating for **self-rule or "Purna Swaraj"** (complete independence).
- While the Congress had initially sought **dominion status** (semi-independent status under the British Crown), the growing influence of leaders like **Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose** pushed the INC toward demanding full independence.
- Conversely, the All-India Muslim League, led by Muhammad Ali Jinnah, began asserting the need for a separate state for Muslims, fearing that a free India would be dominated by the Hindu majority.
- The socio-political landscape in India was also evolving, with increasing awareness among the masses about self-governance, democratic rights, and freedom.

- Political ideologies were converging and diverging, and the British were struggling to maintain control over an increasingly assertive population.
- The period from **1939 to 1947** is, therefore, an era marked by:
  - An unyielding demand for freedom, which became **non-negotiable for Indian leaders.**
  - Ideological and communal negotiations revealed the challenges of uniting a diverse nation.
  - A war-weary British Empire unable to sustain its colonial dominion.
  - The tragic culmination of communal conflicts led to the painful Partition of India.



Key Events in the Indian Freedom Movement (1939–1947)

Year	Event	Description
1939	**Britain involves India in WWII**	Congress ministries resigned in protest.
1940	**August Offer**	Proposal for Dominion status; rejected by Congress.

1940-41	**Individual Satyagraha**	Launched by Gandhi as a symbolic protest; limited participation.
1942	**Cripps Mission**	Proposal for post-war Dominion status; rejected by Congress.
1942	**Quit India Movement**	Mass protests demanding "Quit India"; were suppressed by British authorities.
1944	**Rajagopalachari Formula**	Proposal for Congress-League cooperation; rejected by Jinnah.
1945	**Wavell Plan and Shimla Conference**	Attempts for power-sharing; failed due to the Muslim League's demands.
1945	**Desai-Liaquat Pact**	Aimed at fostering cooperation between Congress and the Muslim League, proposing equal representation in a future government. • However, disagreements over key issues prevented any substantial agreement.
1945-46	**INA Trials**	Trials spark nationalism; and increase public support for independence.
1946	**Cabinet Mission Plan**	The proposal to avoid partition; later led to disagreements.
1946	**Direct Action Day**	Called by the Muslim League; led to communal violence in Calcutta.
1946	**Interim Government**	Led by Nehru; faced challenges from the League.
1947	**Mountbatten Plan**	Plan for Partition and Independence by August 15, 1947.

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July 1947	**Indian Independence Act**	Legislative end of British rule; creation of India and Pakistan.

World War II and India's Involvement (1939)

Background:

- In **September 1939,** World War II broke out, posing a threat to global stability.
- The British Empire, needing resources and manpower, hastily declared India a participant in the war on the side of the Allies without consulting Indian leaders or seeking the consent of the Indian population.

Congress Response:

- The Indian National Congress, led by leaders like **Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Patel,** saw this unilateral decision as a violation of Indian sovereignty.
- Congress had long been cooperating with the British under the hope of progressive autonomy but realized the British would not grant independence as long as India was a colonial asset.

Resignation of Congress Ministries:

- In protest, Congress ministries across several provinces resigned from their posts, signaling a clear break from cooperating with the colonial administration.

Significance:

- This decision marked a turning point, as Indian leaders and the general populace became increasingly vocal about full independence, viewing **dominion status as insufficient.**

The August Offer (1940)

Context:

- The British government, sensing the increasing dissatisfaction among Indians, issued the **"August Offer"** to pacify Congress and gain India's support in the war.

Key Provisions:

- The promise of **dominion status** after the war.
- **Expansion of the Viceroy's Executive Council** to include more Indian members.
- Assurances that **no constitutional changes would be made** without Indian approval.

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Response:

- **Congress rejected the offer**, demanding complete independence.
- The Muslim League, however, saw it as an acknowledgment of its demand for a separate Muslim state.

Outcome:

- The **August Offer failed to ease tensions,** but it demonstrated that the British were aware of the growing demand for self-rule, and it foreshadowed the inevitability of constitutional changes in India.

Individual Satyagraha (1940-1941)

Background:

- Following the rejection of the August Offer, **Mahatma Gandhi launched the Individual Satyagraha** as a way to keep the freedom struggle alive without hampering the British war effort.
- This was a symbolic protest meant to demonstrate the Indian r**ight to free speech and non-violent resistance.**

Key Participants:

- **Vinoba Bhave** was chosen as the **first Satyagrahi**, followed by Jawaharlal Nehru and other prominent leaders.
- They undertook peaceful protests and open declarations against British rule.
- **Pt. Jawaharlal nehru** was selected as the the **second Satyagrahi** for this movement.

Outcome:

- Though largely symbolic and not disruptive, the movement kept nationalist sentiment high and reminded the British that Indian resistance was ongoing.

Cripps Mission (1942)

Context:

- As WWII escalated, **British Prime Minister Winston Churchill** sent **Sir Stafford Cripps** to India to negotiate support for the war.

Proposals:

- India would be **granted dominion status** after the war.

- Provinces would have the option to opt out of the Indian federation.
- **An elected body** would be tasked with drafting a new constitution.

Reaction:

- The **Congress rejected the proposal** because it lacked provisions for immediate independence and allowed the possibility of partition.
- The ambiguity surrounding these terms further aggravated Indian leaders, who felt it was another delaying tactic.

Significance:

- The failure of the Cripps Mission deepened the **divide between Indian leaders and the British**, with Congress becoming increasingly adamant about its demand for independence.

Quit India Movement (1942)

Launch:

- On **August 8, 1942**, the Congress, at its **Bombay session,** declared the Quit India Movement, with Gandhi giving his famous **"Do or Die" speech.**

Objective:

- This was a mass protest demanding an immediate end to British rule in India.

Nature of the Movement:

- Widespread participation across India, **involving demonstrations, strikes, and acts of sabotage.**
- Government buildings were targeted, transportation lines were disrupted, and communication networks were damaged.
- Prominent leaders of underground activities were – **Aruna Asaf Ali, Achyut Patwardhan, Sucheta Kripalani, Ram Manohar Lohia, Biju Patnaik, Chootubhai Puranik, R. P. Goenka and Jayaprakash Narayan.**

British Response:

- The British responded with intense repression, arresting key leaders, including Gandhi, Nehru, and Patel, and using military force to crush the movement.

Outcome:

- Though suppressed violently, the Quit India Movement sent a strong message to the British and the world that Indians would accept nothing short of full independence.

Rajagopalachari Formula (1944)

Objective:

- With the increasing division between Congress and the Muslim League, **C. Rajagopalachari**, a senior Congress leader, proposed a compromise to unite the two factions.

Provisions:

- **Muslim-majority areas** would decide on separation after the war.
- Both sides would agree on **defense, foreign affairs, and communications.**

Response:

- **Jinnah rejected the proposal,** as he wanted a guaranteed separate nation for Muslims. Congress also hesitated, as this suggested a partition was possible.

Outcome:

- The **failure of the Rajagopalachari Formula** highlighted the growing communal divide and the difficulties in achieving a unified solution for India's future.

Wavell Plan and Shimla Conference (1945)

Proposed by:

- **Lord Wavell, the Viceroy of India**, who suggested restructuring the Executive Council to include more Indian members, with equal representation for **Muslims and Hindus.**

Shimla Conference:

- It was held to negotiate the details, but the conference ended in **deadlock as the Muslim League insisted on exclusive rights** to nominate Muslim representatives, a demand Congress opposed.

Outcome:

- The **failure of the Shimla Conference** underscored the widening gap between Congress and the Muslim League and foreshadowed the demand for a separate Muslim nation.

Indian National Army (INA) and Subhas Chandra Bose (1943-1945)

Background:

- **Subhas Chandra Bose** sought to liberate India through an armed struggle. With Japanese support, he reorganized the INA, composed of Indian POWs captured by the Japanese.
- Bose's INA launched a military campaign in northeastern India, aiming to weaken British control.
- In **1945**, the British tried INA officers for treason, sparking massive public support across India, as many Indians saw the INA soldiers as freedom fighters.

Significance:

- Although the INA was defeated, its efforts inspired Indians and increased pressure on the British.

Cabinet Mission Plan (1946)

Objective:

- The British government sent the **Cabinet Mission** to find a solution that would avoid partition and satisfy both Congress and the Muslim League.

Proposals:

- **A federal government** with significant autonomy for provinces.
- Grouping of provinces into three sections based on **communal majorities.**

Response:

- Congress and the Muslim League initially accepted the plan, but later disagreements, especially over the grouping of provinces, led to the League's insistence on a separate state.

Significance:

- **The failure of the Cabinet Mission Plan** further highlighted the communal divide and made partition seem inevitable.

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RIN Mutiny

Date and Event:

- The mutiny began on **February 18, 1946,** and involved sailors of the **Royal Indian Navy (RIN).**

Causes:

- **Poor living conditions:** The sailors faced inadequate food, poor hygiene, and harsh working conditions.
- **Racial discrimination:** Indian sailors were treated inferior to their British counterparts.
- **Inadequate pay:** Sailors' wages were very low, and they were often denied their allowances.
- **Political frustration:** Growing discontent with British rule and the delay in India's independence.

Spread of the Mutiny:

- The mutiny initially began in **Bombay (now Mumbai)**, but quickly spread to 56 ships and shore establishments across India.
- Over **10,000 sailors participated in the mutiny**, which extended to naval units in Calcutta, Madras, and other parts of India.

Support and Ideological Unity:

- Sailors displayed flags of the Indian National Congress, Muslim League, and Communist Party of India, signifying cross-ideological support.
- Workers and students in major cities like Bombay and Calcutta supported the mutiny by organizing strikes and demonstrations.

Response:

- Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru distanced themselves from the mutiny, fearing it might hinder the ongoing negotiations for India's independence.
- The **Indian National Congress and the Muslim League** did not officially support the mutiny.
- The British responded with the threat of military action but instead chose to negotiate, leading to the surrender of the mutineers.
- The mutiny ended on **February 23, 1946**, with assurances of no severe punishment for the sailors.
- Although the mutiny was suppressed, it was a major embarrassment for the British Raj and revealed the discontent within the Indian armed forces.
- Many mutineers were court-martialed, dismissed, or imprisoned.

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- The uprising led to increased pressure on the **British to expedite India's independence.**

Significance:

- It is seen as a precursor to the broader Indian independence movement and a symbol of the unity and strength of the Indian armed forces.
- The mutiny, though short-lived, accelerated the process of British withdrawal from India, eventually leading to independence in 1947.

Direct Action Day (1946)

Call by:

- The **Muslim League declared Direct Action Day on August 16, 1946**, to press for a separate state.

Events:

- The day led to **communal riots in Calcutta**, resulting in large-scale violence and casualties.

Outcome:

- These events underscored the depth of communal tensions and demonstrated the practical challenges of a unified India, pushing both sides closer to accepting partition as a solution.

Formation of the Interim Government (1946)

Headed by:

- **Jawaharlal Nehru,** with members from Congress and the Muslim League.

Challenges:

- The Muslim League's initial hesitation and eventual lack of cooperation created a tense and dysfunctional government.

Outcome:

- The interim government was a critical step toward self-governance but highlighted the irreconcilable differences between Congress and the League.

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Mountbatten Plan (1947)

Presented by:

- **Lord Mountbatten,** the last Viceroy, recommended partition to resolve the ongoing crisis.

Provisions:

- Creation of two separate states, **India and Pakistan.**
- Independence by **August 15, 1947.**

Outcome:

- Congress and the Muslim League accepted the plan, paving the way for partition and independence.

Indian Independence Act (July 1947)

Passed by:

- The British Parliament, formally ending British sovereignty over India.

Key Provisions:

- Establishment of India and Pakistan as independent dominions.
- Transfer of legislative powers to respective assemblies.

Significance:

- Marked the official end of British rule and led to one of the largest migrations in history, accompanied by widespread communal violence.

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